

FPFK KERICHO TOWN CHURCH

Diploma Programme in Pastoral Care & Counselling

PASTORAL EXHORTATION

Understanding Your Ministry Context:
Knowing Where God Has Placed You

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A WORD TO THOSE CALLED TO SERVE

Dear fellow servant of God, before you prepare a single sermon, before you counsel a single soul, before you administer a single programme — you must first ask yourself a fundamental question: Where exactly has God placed me, and what does that place demand of me?

Too many pastors rush into ministry activity without first pausing to understand the field in which they labour. They import methods from other contexts, imitate models from other cultures, and wonder why their work bears little fruit. The truth is plain: faithful ministry is always contextual ministry.

[PREACHER'S NOTE] *Pause here and speak directly to your congregation. Ask them: Have you ever tried to plant a crop in the wrong season? Ministry without contextual understanding is exactly that — good seed sown out of season.*

I went to Jerusalem and, after staying there three days I set out during the night with a few others. I had not told anyone what my God had put in my heart to do for Jerusalem. There were no mounts with me except the one I was riding on.

— **Nehemiah 2:11–12**

Nehemiah did not begin building. He did not deliver rallying speeches. He did not form committees. He first rode silently through the rubble — learning the geography of the problem, internalising the extent of the damage, understanding the context. Only then did he speak, plan, and lead. This is the model for every pastor.

I. WHAT IS MINISTRY CONTEXT?

Ministry context refers to the totality of conditions — geographical, cultural, social, economic, historical, and spiritual — within which a pastor exercises his or her calling. It is the living environment in which the gospel must take root and grow. Understanding context is not a luxury for the sophisticated pastor; it is a basic duty of every faithful shepherd.

A. The Four Dimensions of Context

1. The Geographic and Demographic Dimension

Who are your people? Where do they live? What is the physical landscape of your parish? A pastor serving a tea-farming community in the Kericho highlands ministers in a context shaped by seasonal cycles, communal labour patterns, economic vulnerabilities tied to market prices, and a culture of hard physical toil. A pastor in an urban centre faces a congregation fragmented by mobility, anonymity, and the pressure of competitive individualism. Neither context is superior; both are demanding. But you cannot serve one with the strategies designed for the other.

Contextual Question: *Who are the people in my parish — their age distribution, occupational profiles, education levels, family structures, and migration patterns?*

2. The Cultural and Ethnic Dimension

Culture is the water in which your congregation swims. It shapes how people receive authority, how they process grief, how they understand healing, how they relate to the spiritual world, and what they consider honourable or shameful. African Traditional Religion and culture continue to exert profound influence on the worldview of many who sit in our pews. A contextually intelligent pastor does not simply preach against culture blindly — he engages it, discerns within it, redeems where redemption is possible, and confronts where confrontation is necessary.

[PREACHER'S NOTE] *Draw on personal illustrations here. You might ask: What cultural practice in your community most needs the transforming light of the gospel right now?*

from Issachar, men who understood the times and knew what Israel should do — 200 chiefs, with all their relatives under their command.

— 1 Chronicles 12:32

The sons of Issachar are our model. They were not merely warriors — they were interpreters of their age. Israel needed men who understood the times. Your congregation and community need you to be a son or daughter of Issachar — a pastor who reads the cultural moment with clarity and responds with wisdom.

3. The Socio-Economic Dimension

Poverty, unemployment, land disputes, educational inequality, gender-based violence, substance abuse — these are not merely social problems. They are pastoral challenges. A pastor who is blind to the economic suffering of his congregation will preach sermons that feel irrelevant to those crushed by the weight of unpaid school fees or a failed harvest. The gospel speaks to the whole person. Contextual ministry engages the whole person.

4. The Spiritual and Ecclesiastical Dimension

Every community has a spiritual history. What covenants were made on this land? What altars were erected in the past? What denominational presence or absence has shaped people's experience of church? What wounds have been inflicted by previous pastoral failures? What movements — revival, syncretism, false prophecy — have left their mark? A pastor who does not know the spiritual topography of his terrain will be ambushed by forces he never anticipated.

Preacher's Reflection: *Paul reasoned from the altar to the Unknown God (Acts 17:23). He did not ignore the context; he entered it and redirected it toward Christ.*

II. WHY CONTEXTUAL IGNORANCE IS COSTLY

It must be said plainly: pastoral ignorance of context is not merely an academic deficiency. It has real, costly consequences — for congregations, for communities, and for the advance of God's kingdom. Let us name several:

- **Irrelevant Preaching:** When the pastor does not know the lived realities of the congregation, sermons become abstract — theologically correct perhaps, but existentially disconnected. People leave unchanged not because the Word lacks power, but because it was not applied with precision.
- **Misdiagnosed Pastoral Problems:** A counsellor who does not understand context mistakes spiritual oppression for psychological weakness, confuses cultural grief practices for lack of faith, or applies Western therapeutic models to situations demanding an African communal response.
- **Imported Ministry Models:** Many pastors attempt to replicate urban mega-church models in rural settings, or Western individualistic discipleship approaches in communally-oriented African cultures. The result is a church that looks like a copy of something from elsewhere and feels foreign to the people it was meant to serve.
- **Spiritual Vulnerability:** A pastor unaware of the spiritual dynamics of his context is like a soldier who has not surveyed the battlefield. He will be surprised by the enemy's strategies, blind to the strongholds that must be confronted, and ineffective in leading his congregation to spiritual victory.
- **Stunted Mission:** The Great Commission is not merely to preach in all nations but to make disciples — contextualised, rooted disciples who become agents of transformation in their own communities. This is impossible when the pastor himself is a stranger to the context.

[PREACHER'S NOTE] *Nehemiah wept, fasted, and prayed before he surveyed. This is important: contextual understanding must begin not with data, but with intercession. Pray before you assess.*

III. THE BIBLICAL PATTERN OF CONTEXTUAL MINISTRY

The Scriptures are replete with ministers who took context seriously. This is not a modern missiological innovation — it is the ancient pattern of faithful, God-sent servants.

A. Moses: Forty Years in the Wilderness

Before God sent Moses to Egypt, He placed him in the desert of Midian for forty years. Those years were not wasted. Moses was learning geography, learning survival, learning the wilderness that Israel would one day traverse. God was preparing His servant through immersion in a context. Do not despise your years of formation in a difficult or obscure context. God is teaching you something you will need.

B. Paul: The Man Who Read Every Room

The Apostle Paul is perhaps the supreme biblical model of contextual ministry. In Athens he engaged Greek philosophy (Acts 17). In Corinth he worked as a tentmaker to contextualise his presence among the working class (Acts 18:3). To the Jews he became as a Jew, to those under the law as under the law, to those without law as without law — all for the sake of the

gospel (1 Corinthians 9:20–22). This was not compromise. It was masterful contextual intelligence in the service of unwavering truth.

I have become all things to all people so that by all possible means I might save some.
— 1 Corinthians 9:22

C. Jesus: The Word Dwelling Among Us

The Incarnation is the ultimate act of contextual theology. The eternal Son of God did not shout the gospel from heaven. He entered our context — our flesh, our village, our language, our cultural moment. He spoke of seeds and harvests to agrarian communities. He spoke of yeast and bread to people who baked daily. He engaged Pharisees with legal precision and tax collectors with grace at a dinner table. He wept at Lazarus's tomb because He understood the depth of human grief. Contextual ministry, at its best, is incarnational ministry.

[PREACHER'S NOTE] *This is a powerful place to slow down and dwell. Ask your congregation: What would it look like for your church to truly become flesh in your community — to genuinely live in, with, and for the people around you?*

IV. PRACTICAL STEPS TO UNDERSTANDING YOUR CONTEXT

Contextual understanding does not come automatically. It is cultivated through deliberate, Spirit-led inquiry. Here are practical disciplines every pastor should adopt:

1. Pray Contextually

Begin with intercession — not a general prayer for 'the world,' but specific, named, located prayer. Pray over the map of your parish. Walk the streets and pray. Kneel at the crossroads of your community and intercede. Ask the Holy Spirit to open your eyes to what He sees in this place. Many pastors know their context intellectually but have never wept over it prophetically, as Nehemiah did (Nehemiah 1:4) and as Jesus did over Jerusalem (Luke 19:41).

2. Listen Before You Lead

Commit to sustained listening in the early months of any new assignment. Visit homes. Sit in community meetings. Attend local cultural events. Drink tea with the elders. Listen to the stories of the place — its founding narratives, its tragedies, its seasons of grace. A pastor who is known as a listener will be trusted as a leader.

Principle: *The speed of your contextual learning should exceed the speed of your programmatic interventions. Survey before you build, as Nehemiah did.*

3. Study the Demographics

Obtain basic demographic data about your parish: age distribution, predominant tribes and languages, literacy rates, unemployment figures, disease burdens, school enrolment levels.

Where does your congregation's profile fit in the broader community? Who is absent from your church that should be there? Whose voice is missing from your leadership structures?

4. Trace the Spiritual History

Research the spiritual history of your location. Interview older believers about past revivals, past church conflicts, past spiritual breakthroughs and setbacks. Discern the dominant spiritual atmosphere. Are there patterns of repeated conflict, persistent sin, chronic failure in certain areas? These may reflect spiritual conditions that require prophetic intervention, not merely better programming.

5. Engage in Community Needs Assessment

Conduct a structured community needs assessment at least once every three years. Use questionnaires, focus groups, and key informant interviews. Involve your congregation in the process — this itself is a form of ministry, as it signals that the church takes the community's suffering seriously. The findings should directly shape your preaching calendar, pastoral priorities, and community engagement programmes.

6. Read Broadly

A pastor who reads only devotional literature is a pastor who will misread his context. Read sociology, read local history, read denominational reports, read government development plans for your region. Read African theology — scholars like John Mbiti, Kwame Bediako, and Jesse Mugambi have done vital work in helping the church engage the African context faithfully. Read widely, and let your reading inform your ministry.

[PREACHER'S NOTE] *Recommend specific texts or resources here if you are using this as a lecture exhortation. You may refer to course readings already assigned in the Diploma Programme.*

V. CAUTIONS FOR THE CONTEXTUAL PASTOR

Let this exhortation be balanced by necessary cautions. Contextual awareness is not an invitation to every error that bears its name:

Caution 1: Context Must Never Compromise the Gospel

Contextualisation is the communication method, not the content. The death and resurrection of Jesus Christ, the call to repentance and faith, the authority of Scripture, the reality of judgment and salvation — these are not negotiable based on cultural preference. Some things are not contextual; they are universal. The pastor's task is to hold firmly to the unchanging gospel while communicating it with cultural intelligence.

Caution 2: Sympathy Must Not Become Syncretism

Understanding African Traditional Religion and culture does not mean absorbing it uncritically into Christian practice. There are elements of African culture that the gospel affirms and redeems — communal solidarity, respect for elders, care for the earth. But there are also elements that the gospel confronts and transforms — ancestral appeasement,

practices that oppress women and children, covenants made with darkness. Contextual engagement requires both affirmation and confrontation, guided at every point by Scripture and the Holy Spirit.

Caution 3: Context-Sensitivity Must Not Become People-Pleasing

There is a temptation for the contextually-aware pastor to become so attuned to what his congregation wants to hear that he ceases to preach what they need to hear. The prophet Jeremiah was deeply contextual — he lamented in the language of his people, engaged their cultural idioms — but he never softened the word of the Lord to gain approval. Be contextually intelligent, but remain prophetically courageous.

Preach the word; be prepared in season and out of season; correct, rebuke and encourage — with great patience and careful instruction. For the time will come when people will not put up with sound doctrine.

— **2 Timothy 4:2–3**

VI. A FINAL WORD: YOU ARE PLANTED, NOT PARACHUTED

God does not parachute pastors into communities as observers who hover above the fray. He plants them — as trees planted by rivers of water (Psalm 1:3), whose roots go down deep into the specific soil of a specific place. Your context is not an obstacle to your ministry. It is the very field of your ministry.

Understand where God has placed you. Love that place. Weep over it. Study it. Pray over it. Know its stories. Know its wounds. Know its hopes. And then, with every gift the Holy Spirit has entrusted to you, serve it — until the Lord of the harvest looks upon your labour and says: Well done.

Also, seek the peace and prosperity of the city to which I have carried you into exile. Pray to the Lord for it, because if it prospers, you too will prosper.

— **Jeremiah 29:7**

Closing Charge: Go back to your context this week. Walk through it with new eyes — Spirit-opened eyes. Ask God: What do You see here that I have been missing? What am I called to speak, to confront, to heal, to build in this specific place?

Rev. Gideon Yegon | FPFK Kericho Town Church | June 2026
